

has the potential to boom if several recent central and state government initiatives are successful. “Throughout our growth journey, we have been fighting with one hand tied because we didn’t have access to enough technology, enough funds, enough government backing. That’s always a challenge because we are an emerging segment and it’s a very important part of the global business today,” says DNEG’s Tavaria.

In recent times, both central and state governments have been giving a push to the animation, visual effects, gaming and comics (AVGC) industry, which was recognised as a Champion Sector in 2018. Acknowledging the revenue generation and job creation potential of the sector, the central government has constituted an AVGC promotion task force to drive policy, expand exports and attract FDI. There is also talk of extending incentives under the flagship Service Exports from India Scheme (SEIS) to the industry. States such as Maharashtra, Karnataka, Telangana and Assam have created special policies to promote the sector.

Then, not unlike several other growing industries, the segment is facing a talent deficit. “We are always running short of artists. If tomorrow you get me 20 good artists, we will hire them on the spot!” says Bakshi. “Here the fight is not for work from film studios—there is ample amount of that—but about retaining artists.” Therefore, in addition to creating physical infrastructure such as studios and technical facilities, what is also needed is setting up specialised seats of learning, and undergraduate and postgraduate courses in partnership with foreign studios and universities.

Others feel that the high rate of attrition can only be balanced through the creation of a strong set of standards to govern the industry. “There has to be government bodies, forums and industry standards to take care of how a project comes in, how it gets allocated, how it gets done, and what should be the financial and time factors attached



“Not only does [VFX] create a superior experience for the viewers, it also gives opportunities to film-makers and artists to expand their visual creativity”

KEITAN YADAV
COO, RED CHILLIES
ENTERTAINMENT



“As a service provider, even we are better placed now with the experience that is available at our fingertips”

MERZIN TAVARIA
PRESIDENT,
GLOBAL
PRODUCTION &
OPERATIONS, DNEG

to it,” says Suchit Mukherjee, Founding Partner & CEO, Famulus Media & Entertainment. “All of that will help in closing the existing gaps.”

Meanwhile, companies like Phantom VFX are taking several initiatives like visiting university campuses and grooming talent by taking on board people with good skills in art or technology for three-month-long paid training programmes. “We are in touch with the Media and Entertainment Sector Council (MESC) to reach out to all the universities to get to the right talent pool across states. We also try to encourage people at various events to join the industry,” says Rajan of Phantom VFX.

Since VFX is a pure technology play, it is bound to keep evolving at a rapid clip. In such a scenario, merely retaining a competitive advantage where a VFX or animation expert is available at one-fifth the price of her western peers may not suffice. “We still need to cover considerable distance in terms of timing and costing. Yes, sometimes the creative thoughts and inputs are dictated from the outside. The reason being a large chunk of our work is like factory work. We can put more creative inputs and energies into it if time and cost are balanced to create more intellectual creative leaders who can lead from the inception stage to final delivery,” says Mukherjee.

India has some distance to go to seriously compete with other global hubs such as Montreal and London, which offer skilled workers together with other lucrative incentives to studios. This has resulted in the VFX segment in Montreal growing at a CAGR of 25 per cent, while London is already regarded as Europe’s VFX capital.

In addition to ensuring an effective roll-out of the government’s AVGC policy, training and upskilling also require a tremendous push to ensure that Indian VFX studios continue to enthral and awe a global audience with alien invasions and flying dragons. **BT**

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